# Project meeting 3: Coherence in academic writing

**Minidiss 26/27 with Dr. Elizabeth Pankratz**
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## 1 What is coherence?

If it's easy to follow the flow of a piece of writing from one idea to the next—if the ideas are organised in a logical, sensible way—then we say that that writing is **coherent**.

### 1.1 Small group activity 1: Coherence between sentences

Arrange the sentences in the envelope into the order you believe the authors intended. Use your intuitions, your instincts, and your expectations as a reader. Be prepared for someone in your group to read the reordered paragraph out loud and to try to explain why you ordered it the way you did.

(Original paragraph from Saffran et al. 1996.)

### 1.2 A key principle: "Given before new"

Which of the following sections flows better?

**Option 1**

To identify words in a continuous stream of speech, people seem to use a clustering mechanism. Using transitional probability, a statistical measure, we therefore endeavored to formalize the idea of the clustering mechanism.

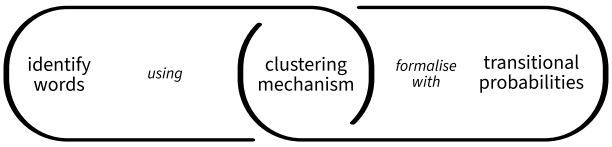
**Option 2**

To identify words in a continuous stream of speech, people seem to use a clustering mechanism. We therefore endeavored to formalize the idea of the clustering mechanism using a statistical measure: transitional probability.

(Options paraphrased from Saffran et al. 1996.)

Readers expect that you will start with familiar information (also called "given" information). Then they expect that you'll use that information to build toward new information. It's good to write in a way that matches readers' expectations.

Readers feel like a text flows when sentences build a "chain" of ideas. This chain of ideas gets them from the starting point (what they're already familiar with) to where we want them to go.




Tips for using the "given before new" principle:

- Information that was "new" in one sentence can be treated as "given" in the next sentence. That information is where two links in the chain of ideas meet.
- Treat technical terms as "new" information. If you have to introduce a technical term, put it at the end of the sentence (even if you have to invent a whole new sentence to do so).
- How do you know what information to treat as "new"? Think about it like this: **What information would be new to your coursemates who are on a different minidiss project?**
- **Specifically for lit reviews:** If you start a sentence by naming authors, this will probably disrupt the flow. It's usually better to start with the key topic/concept and just cite the authors in parentheses at the end.

## 1.3 Small group activity 2: Coherence between paragraphs

Activity 1 had a good topic sentence. Topic sentences have two purposes:

1. To express a paragraph's main point and suggest its structure.
2. To transition from the paragraph before.

**Part 1 of 4**

Here's the opening line of Pellicano and Burr (2012):

> Autism is a heritable, lifelong neurodevelopmental condition that has its most striking effects on social communication – the so-called social symptoms. Yet the condition is also defined by a less well-researched range of non-social symptoms.

Make a prediction: What do you think the rest of this paragraph will be about? Why?

**Important: The goal of this exercise is not to "get the right answer". There is no "right answer".**

The goal of the exercise is to get to know your own expectations as a reader and where they come from. Understanding your expectations is useful because it'll help you write in a way that satisfies them.

**Part 2 of 4**

Here's the entire first paragraph.

> Autism is a heritable, lifelong neurodevelopmental condition that has its most striking effects on social communication – the so-called social symptoms. Yet the condition is also defined by a less well-researched range of non-social symptoms. These symptoms present throughout development, are prevalent in autistic individuals regardless of intellectual ability, and vary widely from an intense desire for sameness (like following rigid routines) and sensory atypicalities (such as extreme sensitivity to fluorescent lighting or to the sound of the school bell) to remarkable talents (such as an excellent eye for detail).

Did this paragraph align with your prediction?

Now, make a new prediction: What are a few plausible topics/themes that the next paragraph could start with?

**Part 3 of 4**

Now here's the same text, including the first sentence of the second paragraph.

> Autism is a heritable, lifelong neurodevelopmental condition that has its most striking effects on social communication – the so-called social symptoms. Yet the condition is also defined by a less well-researched range of non-social symptoms. These symptoms present throughout development, are prevalent in autistic individuals regardless of intellectual ability, and vary widely from an intense desire for sameness (like following rigid routines) and sensory atypicalities (such as extreme sensitivity to fluorescent lighting or to the sound of the school bell) to remarkable talents (such as an excellent eye for detail).
>
> These symptoms feature prominently in the draft changes to the forthcoming diagnostic guidelines for autism [1] but the range and idiosyncrasy of sensory atypicalities in particular still represent some of the most puzzling features of autism.

(The [1] in the new sentence is a reference that uses a non-APA citation style.)

Did this topic sentence align with your prediction?

Now, make a new prediction: What do you expect the rest of this second paragraph to be about? What makes you think so?

**Part 4 of 4**

Finally, here are the full two first paragraphs of Pellicano and Burr (2012):

> Autism is a heritable, lifelong neurodevelopmental condition that has its most striking effects on social communication – the so-called social symptoms. Yet the condition is also defined by a less well-researched range of non-social symptoms. These symptoms present throughout development, are prevalent in autistic individuals regardless of intellectual ability, and vary widely from an intense desire for sameness (like following rigid routines) and sensory atypicalities (such as extreme sensitivity to florescent lighting or to the sound of the school bell) to remarkable talents (such as an excellent eye for detail).
>
> These symptoms feature prominently in the draft changes to the forthcoming diagnostic guidelines for autism [1] but the range and idiosyncrasy of sensory atypicalities in particular still represent some of the most puzzling features of autism. They include not only hypersensitivity to incoming stimuli but also hyposensitivity to stimuli and sensory seeking behaviours such as attraction to light, intense looking at objects and fascination with brightly coloured objects [2, 3]. Indeed, they often oscillate between these states within the same individual. They can also have catastrophic effects on the lives of autistic people. As Donna Williams reports first hand: "the sensory overload caused by bright lights, fluorescent lights, colours, and patterns makes the body react as if being attacked or bombarded, resulting in such physical symptoms as headaches, anxiety, panic attacks or aggression" [4, p. 43].

Across all these examples, notice how the topic sentence sets the theme for the rest of the paragraph. And the remaining sentences go into detail, building and elaborating on this theme.

If you write your sentences, paragraphs, and sections using this structure, then your reader will feel well taken care of.

### 1.4 General recommendations for writing coherently

- Highlight all the places in your writing where one sentence starts by building on the information from the end of the sentence before. You want to have lots of highlights! If you can't find many places like this, then your reader won't be able to either.
- Ask somebody else to read your writing and give you comments on its "flow". Ask them to mark any places where they feel like things break down. Then try to smooth out those places. You can do this by writing sentences that put familiar, given information before new information (even if you have to make up more new sentences to do it).
- For each paragraph, try to summarise its key point using just one sentence (or better yet, ask somebody else to try!). If this task feels weird or difficult, then probably your paragraph is not conveying its message clearly enough.
- If you end up summarising a paragraph with a sentence that's not actually what you wanted to convey, then try writing a new sentence that *does* represent what you want to say. This sentence you've just written could be a good topic sentence. Try writing a new paragraph around it instead.

## 2 Elizabeth's favourite books about writing

- Williams, J. M. (1990). Style: Toward clarity and grace. University of Chicago Press.
- Sword, H. (2012). Stylish academic writing. Harvard University Press.

Also, look at Clark (2000), linked in the website sidebar. It's pretty quick to read and contains loads of good advice.

## References


Pellicano, E., & Burr, D. (2012). When the world becomes 'too real': A Bayesian explanation of autistic perception. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*, *16*(10), 504–510. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tics.2012.08.009

Saffran, J. R., Newport, E. L., & Aslin, R. N. (1996). Word segmentation: The role of distributional cues. *Journal of Memory and Language*, *35*(4), 606–621. https://doi.org/10.1006/jmla.1996.0032